destiny?

. Abdul Qadir Badauni, *Muntakhab-ut-Tawarikh* (Selections from Histories), vol. 2, trans. W.H. Lowe (first published 1884–98; Atlantic Publishers and Distributors, 1990). This particular phrase, however, is translated by H.M. Elliot in the extracts of Badauni's work published in *The History of India, As Told by Its Own Historians*, vol. 5 (Trübner and Co., 1873).

Badauni's secret history was published after the emperor's demise, naturally, and promptly banned by his successor, thus becoming an instant hit. See Azfar Moin, *The Millennial Sovereign: Sacred Kingship & Sainthood in Islam* (Columbia University Press, 2012).

. Abu'l Fazl, *The Akbarnama of Abu'l Fazl* (completed by Inayatullah), vol. 1, trans. Henry Beveridge (First published 1902–1939; Low Price Publications, 2017).

. Nizamuddin Ahmad, 'Tabakat-i Akbari', in *The History of India, As Told by Its Own Historians*, trans. H.M. Elliot, vol. 5 (Trübner and Co., 1873).

. His battle cry was 'Either martyrdom or victory', because, as he explained to anyone who asked why he wouldn't put victory first, Husain Khan would rather 'see the glorious departed, than the lords who remain alive'. See Badauni, *Muntakhab-ut-Tawarikh*, trans. W.H. Lowe.

. Husain Quli tried to mollify the disappointed warrior by showing him around the battlefield, telling him all the stories, and letting him chase after Mirza Ibrahim. It may be that Husain Quli was feeling a bit guilty. Husain Khan had written to him before he arrived, asking him to delay the battle by a day: '. . . if you would let me be a participator in this victory, and postpone the battle one day, it would be only friendly.' Husain Quli had replied with a friendly enough yes, but ignored the request.

.Badauni, *Muntakhab-ut-Tawarikh*, trans. W.H. Lowe.

. P.P. Sinha, *Raja Birbal: Life and Times* (Janaki Prakashan, 1980).

. Akbar described Birbar thus in a letter to another of his favourites, Abdur Rahim. See Sinha, *Raja Birbal*.

. Now better known as Kangra.

. Harbans Mukhia, citing S.R. Sharma's record of a local tradition, writes that Akbar sent a golden umbrella for the temple's deity as a way to 'make amends' for the bloody siege. See Harbans Mukhia, *The Mughals of India* (Blackwell Publishing, 2004; Indian reprint by Wiley India, 2018). The *Akbarnama*, too, records that Akbar wanted to visit the Nagarkot temple in the twenty-sixth year of his reign, 1581–82, a decade or so after the battle at the shrine. The road was difficult but no one dared dissuade the emperor until Akbar himself had a dream telling him to return. At this, writes Abul Fazl, 'A great delight took possession of everyone'. See *The Akbarnama of Abu'l Fazl*, vol. 3.

. Such ideas of a second (and final) coming were common across religions and the globe. Christopher Columbus's search for a new route to India, by which he stumbled upon the Americas, derived some of its urgency from the belief in an imminent return of the messiah. As Reginald Stackhouse explains it, Columbus's sponsors, the Spanish royalty, hoped that the 'fabled wealth of the East would give them up front financing against the infidel – and prepare for Christ's coming at Jerusalem'. Columbus himself hoped that a shortcut to the east would allow Christian missionaries to get there faster and thus 'meet the provision for world evangelization before the Lord could return' (Reginald Stackhouse, 'Columbus's Millennial Voyage', *Christian History*, no. 61, 1999).

. Specifically in the court of Sher Shah Suri's son and successor, Salim Shah.

. Heinrich Blochmann in his introduction to Abu'l Fazl, *The Ain-i-Akbari*, vol. 1, trans. H. Blochmann (First published 1927; Low Price Publications, 2014). Outspoken and intelligent, Shaikh Ala'i 'charmed' Salim (or Islam) Shah, Sher Shah's son and successor, along with many of his courtiers, including Shaikh Mubarak. 'It is not clear', writes Blochmann, whether Abul Fazl's father 'joined the sect from religious or from political motives' – the latter would have been to 'break up the party of the learned at the Court, at whose head Makhdum-ul-Mulk stood'.